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Gov. Newsom signs law increasing penalty for illegal sideshows in California

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Gov. Gavin Newsom signed into law a bill that increases the penalty for participating in illegal vehicle sideshows, which police say have been prevalent and disrupted residential areas across Santa Rosa in recent weeks.

The bipartisan bill paves the way for judges to suspend driver's licenses for up to six months if someone is convicted of participating in the events that typically involve drivers performing stunts in the middle of roads.

"We're going to be supportive of any initiative or law that deters people from participating in sideshows because of how dangerous they are," Santa Rosa police Sgt. Chris Mahurin said.

The bill also establishes the first legal definition for "sideshow" and identifies it as an event involving at least two vehicles that block traffic for the purpose of performing stunts, speed contests or reckless driving for an audience.

"Illegal sideshows continue to devastate families, claim innocent lives in our communities, and create serious risks for our youth," Assemblyman Vince Fong, R- Kern County, said in a statement. "Proactive enforcement is critical to stopping dangerous sideshows before they start."

Fong introduced the bill, but it was co-authored by State Assembly members Laura Friedman, Jesse Gabriel and Adrin Nazarian, and state Sen. Susan Rubio.

All are Democrats from Southern California.

According to Fong's office, the CHP responded to more than 25,000 calls involving illegal street racing activity last year. In Bakersfield, which is part of Fong's district, police received more than 6,000 calls in 2020.

In Santa Rosa, there have been more than 80 calls regarding sideshows this year, Mahurin said.

Police say they've responded to numerous sideshows this year involving small numbers of vehicles. But larger events have taken place on a few occasions, including two that attracted hundreds of people and dozens of vehicles to the intersection of Sebastopol Road and West Avenue on Aug. 27 and Sept. 16.

During the Sept. 16 gathering, two young women suffered stab wounds that were not life threatening. Investigators also found a man suffering from a head injury, but they said it wasn't clear if he was assaulted or fell.

Police said people were hostile during their efforts to disperse the crowd.

On Sept. 30, police impounded four vehicles that were linked to the sideshows. Three more vehicles were impounded about a week ago, Mahurin said.

Each was to be held for 30 days with fees totaling more than $2,500.

Botts' dots were installed at Sebastopol and West as a deterrent to sideshows and reckless driving. Police say the raised dots are arranged to prevent reckless driving like drifting and doughnuts but won't affect anyone driving straight or making turns.

Mahurin said it's still too early to gauge their effectiveness.

You can reach Staff Writer Colin Atagi at colin.atagi@pressdemocrat.com. On Twitter @colin_atagi.

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